

THE MIDNIGHT LINE

Written by

A. Sample

INT. DISPATCH OFFICE – NIGHT

Rain sheets the windows. A wall of monitors throws blue light across MARA REYES (40s), headset on, the only soul awake on the graveyard shift. A single red line blinks on the board.

MARA
Midnight Line, this is dispatch. Say again your location.

Static. Then a voice – calm, too calm.

VOICE (V.O.)
You already know where I am, Mara. You've always known.

Mara's hand freezes over the keyboard. She has never given this caller her name.

MARA
(steady herself)
I'm going to need you to stay on the line with me. Can you do that?

VOICE (V.O.)
I can do that. The question is whether you can.

CUT TO:

EXT. RIVERSIDE – CONTINUOUS

A payphone, impossibly, still standing. The receiver swings on its cord. No one is there. Headlights smear across the wet asphalt and are gone.

VOICE (V.O.)
Twelve calls. Twelve nights. You wrote them all down because you thought writing it down would make it yours. It doesn't work that way.

Back in the office, Mara pulls a worn notebook from the drawer. Pages of handwriting. Dates. Times. The same number every night.

MARA
What do you want from me?

VOICE (V.O.)
To be heard. Same as everyone who's ever dialed these three numbers in the dark. Same as you, the night you didn't pick up.

Mara closes her eyes. Thunder. When she opens them the red

line has gone dark – and every other line on the board is lit.

MARA
(whisper)
Oh god. They're all calling at once.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. DISPATCH OFFICE – MOMENTS LATER

Mara stands, headset cord stretched taut. Forty lines blinking. She reaches for the master switch – and stops. Her own handwriting stares back from the notebook: DON'T HANG UP ON THEM. NOT AGAIN.

MARA
Okay. Okay. One at a time. I'm here. I'm listening.

She presses the first line. Breathes. Begins.

FADE OUT.